

90, AT LAST

Even after winning Olympic and world titles and becoming India's first track-and-field athlete with two Olympic medals, one landmark remained missing from Neeraj Chopra's resume — 90m throw.

He had come agonisingly close. Six centimetres short at the Lausanne Diamond League in 2022. Fifty-five centimetres away at the Paris Olympics in 2024. "I think I will have to leave it up to God now," Neeraj said after settling for silver in Paris.

No one questioned his greatness. Yet the absence of a 90-metre throw lingered. It was a threshold crossed by only 25 javelin throwers since 1986, and for an athlete of Neeraj's stature, it stood out as a quiet but persistent omission.

Returning from injury, his season began modestly with an 84.05m effort at the Potch Invitational Meet in South Africa in April. There was little to suggest what would follow.

A month later in Doha, everything changed. At the Diamond League, Neeraj finally breached the barrier, hurling the javelin 90.23m to become just the 26th man in history to do so and set a new Indian national record. In a year where he surrendered his world title after an eighth-place finish in Tokyo, that throw offered something equally valuable. Not redemption, perhaps, but release. For Neeraj and those who followed his journey, the long chase was finally over.



AHEAD OF TIME

One of the Indian Premier League's most enduring motifs has been the teenager unfazed by its scale and scrutiny. Jasprit Bumrah, Sanju Samson, Rishabh Pant and Yashasvi Jaiswal were all shaped early by the collision of high-stakes T20 cricket and international stardom.

Yet across 18 editions of the league, few have worn the wonderkid tag with the audacity of Vaibhav Suryavanshi.

By the time Rajasthan Royals signed him for Rs. 1.10 crore, Suryavanshi had already debuted for Bihar in first-class and T20 cricket and scored a century for India Under-19s. He spent the opening matches on the bench, but once unleashed, he wasted little time announcing himself.

At 14 years and 23 days, Suryavanshi became the youngest player in IPL history when he was deployed as an Impact Player during a chase of 181 against Lucknow Super Giants. His first ball in the league was dispatched over cover for six, off Shardul Thakur.

Any lingering doubts about his readiness were erased days later. Against Gujarat Titans, Suryavanshi tore into the attack with a 35-ball hundred, the second-fastest in IPL history. At 14 years and 32 days, he also became the youngest centurion in T20 cricket.

The IPL has seen precocity before. Rarely has it been announced with such fearless conviction.

